integral part of this policy.[107] Fourth, the BRI is an important part of China's engagement in Iran and the Middle East.[108] Garver's chapter in this book outlines China's growing partnership with Iran. Half of China's oil imports originate in the Middle East and Iran, and Beijing recently published its first "Arab Policy Paper." An increased Chinese engagement in the region India refers to as West Asia is of concern in New Delhi.

Border relations

In a speech on China's foreign policy in December 2018, China's State Councilor and Minister of Foreign Affairs Wang Yi referred to the meeting between President Xi Jinping and Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Wuhan earlier the same year as a landmark event in China–India relations, enabling deep strategic communication between the two countries. However, in the same speech, Wang Yi also mentioned that Sino–Indian relations in recent years have been "beset by the boundary question and other historical baggage."[109] Notwithstanding China and India conducting more than 20 rounds of border talks since the early 1980s, the border dispute lingers on. Tensions were running high during a standoff between India and China over a remote road on the Doklam plateau in the late summer of 2017,[110] and both in 2013 and 2015, Indian and Chinese troops had a face-off along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Ladakh.[111]

Speculations that China purposefully shows disinterest in resolving the border dispute with India in order to keep the dispute as a bargaining chip[112] will probably remain only speculations. Nevertheless, China has over the last two decades strengthened its position through building infrastructure on the Tibetan plateau and has ambitious plans for connecting with Nepal and Bangladesh.[113]